ZAINAB TAHA

Cybersecurity Student | GRC, Network & Cloud Security, Security Operations
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SUMMARY

Senior Cybersecurity student at Effat University (GPA 3.86/4.00) with hands-on project experience in threat detection, adversary emulation, and compliance automation. Built security tools using Python, Docker, Terraform, CI/CD, and mapped technical controls to MITRE ATT&CK, NIST CSF, ISO 27001, NCA ECC, and PDPL. Seeking a cybersecurity internship starting January 2027.

EDUCATION

Effat University **Jeddah, Saudi Arabia**
Bachelor of Science in Computer Science, Cybersecurity Track | GPA: 3.86 / 4.00 *Expected June 2027*
President's List (2025/2026) – Awarded for maintaining a GPA of 3.9 & higher across two consecutive semesters.
Dean's List (2024/2025) – Awarded for maintaining a GPA of 3.75 & higher across two consecutive semesters.
Relevant Coursework: Governance Risk and Compliance, Computer Networks, Ethical Hacking, Cryptography and Network Security, Digital Forensics, Information and Cyber Security, Software Engineering, Artificial Intelligence.

FEATURED PROJECTS

Purple-Team Lateral Movement Detection Platform | Senior Capstone **Jan 2026 - Present**
Python, Docker, tcpdump, MITRE ATT&CK, NIST CSF, ISO 27001, NCA ECC | github.com/zainabthaa/lateral-movement-showcase

- Architected a segmented, Docker-based enterprise network of 13 containerized hosts across 3 isolated subnets with an inline IDS sensor bridging the segments to execute and detect lateral-movement attacks end-to-end in a red/blue lab.
- Built an adversary-emulation module generating realistic kill-chain traffic, mapped to 20 MITRE ATT&CK techniques to measure detection coverage.
- Developed a GRC module that maps live detection telemetry to NIST CSF, ISO 27001, and NCA ECC controls, auto-generating control-effectiveness evidence, with access governed by just-in-time and least-privilege controls.
- Engineered a custom real-time IDS pipeline combining behavioral analysis and signature-based rules, feeding the SOC triage dashboard with role-based access, alert assignment, and MTTR tracking computed from live alerts.

Compliance-as-Code Policy Enforcement Pipeline **Aug - Sep 2026**
GitHub Actions, Terraform, OPA/Rego, Conftest, Python, AWS | github.com/zainabthaa/compliance-as-code-pipeline

- Designed a CI/CD pipeline in GitHub Actions that checks Terraform plans against security controls with OPA/Rego and Conftest, automatically blocking non-compliant pull requests through branch protection.
- Codified 7 CIS AWS Foundations Benchmark controls and 3 custom checks into 6 Rego policy modules covering S3, RDS, security groups, IAM, EBS, and hardcoded secrets.
- Built a Python layer that generates a report and an HTML dashboard on every run, listing failing resources, reason, and the fix.

NoorPay GRC Engagement: Risk Assessment, Gap Analysis & IR Plan **Apr - May 2026**
NIST SP 800-30, NIST SP 800-61, GDPR, Saudi PDPL, CISO Assistant | github.com/zainabthaa/noorpay-grc-assessment

- Simulated GRC consulting engagement for a Saudi fintech after a breach affecting 12,000 customers; assessed 10 risks (NIST SP 800-30) on a CISO Assistant heat map.
- Audited 12 GDPR/PDPL requirements and wrote a NIST SP 800-61 IR plan with SDAIA/GDPR 72-hour breach notification.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

GRC & Frameworks: MITRE ATT&CK, NIST CSF, NIST SP 800-30, ISO 27001, NCA ECC, Saudi PDPL, GDPR, CIS Benchmarks, security policies, risk and control assessment, gap analysis, control mapping
Networking & Systems: TCP/IP, network segmentation, Linux, Kali Linux, Wireshark, Nmap, tcpdump
Security Operations: SOC monitoring, incident response, intrusion detection, adversary emulation, vulnerability assessment
Cloud & DevSecOps: AWS, IAM, Terraform, Docker, GitHub Actions, OPA/Rego, Conftest, CI/CD security
Programming: Python, JavaScript, Java, C++, PHP, SQL (MySQL), HTML, Bash | **Languages**: Arabic (Native) and English (Fluent)

CERTIFICATIONS

CompTIA Security+ (In Progress)	Expected Jan 2027
Security Operations Center (SOC) Fundamentals – Cisco	May 2026
Introduction to Containers w/ Docker, Kubernetes & OpenShift – IBM	Apr 2026
Introduction to DevOps – IBM	Oct 2025

LEADERSHIP & ACTIVITIES

Nominee, Student Shura Council President – Effat University **2026**

- Nominated for Queen Effat Citizenship Award to serve as Student Shura President and student-body representative.

Vice President, Cyber Security Club – Effat University **2025-2026**

- Co-founded and co-led planning and execution for 4 hands-on labs, competitions and security workshops.

Vice President, Society of Petroleum Engineers (SPE) – SPE Chapter, Effat University **2026-Present**

- Co-founded and co-directed strategic planning and operational execution for technical workshops and community initiatives.